

CHAPTER ONE – THE BEGINNING

A young girl who had just finished her Senior Secondary School Education with the hope of securing an admission to the higher field of learning (University), got her hope dashed by an infamous disease.'

Aisha Abba Abdullahi (triple A) was cheerful, loving, patient, and very positive from her child hood. These qualities made her a strong warrior – the die-hard kind. She had learned from the very beginning the skill of keeping calm even in the face of the most dreadful threats. What baffles all that come across her was her ability to remain positive and optimistic, when every other person had given up over a particular situation. She grew up as a normal child but enviable due to her level of her brilliance and intelligence. She was a child who could have been given an alias "the wise girl."

Birthered in Africa, a continent that gave more attention to the boy child at the expense of the girl child, Aisha gave more to life, and even did better than most of her male peers. As if she knew from the beginning that she had to give more to life, if she would gain public acceptance as a girl child. She focused on her studies and always aspire to be the best amongst her peers, regardless of gender or status.

By academic standard, Aisha justified the concept of gender equality, in the sense that a girl child can perform as much as a boy child. No wonder she was able to secure admission to a prestigious university in Nigeria few months after she completed her senior secondary school certificate education.

In the build up to moving to a citadel of higher learning, Aisha had a family wedding to attend in Kano. Being a child

who was born and raised in Abuja, the Federal Capital Territory of Nigeria, that is hours' drive away from her home state, Adamawa, she had little family functions to attend. So, the news of any family function far or close always excites Aisha. As the news of this wedding ceremony which would be held in Kano State broke, Aisha became extremely excited that she would be attending another family function and at this time she was going to be hundred percent involved, because this was a wedding ceremony of a close family member.

Aisha attended the wedding ceremony and enjoyed every moment of the ceremony, but it was at that same wedding ceremony that Aisha's ordeal began unknowingly.

Who would have thought that in the midst of plenty joy and excitements, there could be what looked like an appearance of sorrow.

While in Kano, before returning to Abuja, Aisha started feeling unwell and weak. She began to exhibit malaria symptoms such as high fever, tiredness, and appetite loss. She was supposed to be picked and taken to the airport by her parent so that she could join a flight to Abuja. This would then mean that there is need for her to get her things together, and be prepared for the journey back to Abuja. Unfortunately, when her parent got to where she was with the hope of meeting her fully prepared and ready to go, it was realised that she was not even an inch prepared to travel. Her parent was surprised by this, because Aisha as known by her parents was the type that always get herself ready ahead of time for any endeavour, and not the type that allowed herself get caught by any eventuality.

Her mother wondered, and started asking questions as to why she had not

arranged her things and get ready to catch her flight back to Abuja. Aisha's response was that she was not feeling well, and she tried to get herself ready but she lacked the strength to do so. This response threw her parents off balance, because this was a girl that had been throwing herself everywhere at the event in Kano for days, and had also been full of energy. So, the question is, why the sudden illness?

There was nothing the mother could do than to help her arrange her things, and prepare her for the journey, so that she doesn't miss her flight.

On getting to Abuja, her mother did not delay to take her to the hospital. Her mother has always been a health enthusiast, so she understood what quality health should look like, and this has consistently helped her to make informed choices and decisions in the way she handles the health of her family. In the hospital, some tests were conducted, and Aisha was diagnosed for malaria. It was also observed she has low blood count, hence, the need for malaria treatment and at the same time set her up for blood transfusion.

Every one believed that once this is done, Aisha would be back on her feet. In this part of the world, malaria has always been a common phenomenon. It has always been part of our health struggles as Africans. Many questions have been asked on why mosquitoes which are the carriers and spreaders of malaria parasites are domicile in Africa. However, many solutions have also been provided to curb the spread of the malaria parasite and probably eradicate the endemic. These solutions range from the practice of personal hygiene, to the introduction of the Long-Lasting Insecticide Net (LLIN), to malaria treatment with chloroquine injection, and most recently the introduction of Artemether and

Lumefantrine tablets as oral treatment. All of these solutions have been very effective but not enough to stop the spread of the malaria parasite.

Perhaps, one day the creator of the planet earth, and of the black people will capture the mother mosquito from wherever she breeds from, put her in the bottomless pit, and cause all mosquitoes to go into extinction.

Being familiar with the term 'malaria,' Aisha's mother had nothing to worry about, but what made her uncomfortable was the fact that her daughter had to be taken in for blood transfusion. Questions brewing in her mind was 'hasn't she been feeding her with enough protein; Did the malaria parasite sucked her blood; could it be that there was an underlying factor responsible for the blood low count that the health personnels refused to tell her.' These questions and more in her mind received no answers. At some point Aisha's mother had her doubt about the competence of the medical personnels on the issue of the blood transfusion because she could not phantom in her head any reason for Aisha to have low blood count let alone getting blood transfusion. But at the end, she resulted to allowing the health experts do their job. In the process, Aisha's mother was able to ask the health experts questions regarding the blood transfusion, and she was told that sometimes malaria can be very severe to the point that the patient would have low blood count, especially when the patient was not treated of the malaria for a long time.

Aisha's mother was convinced by the health experts that the malaria was the reason for the blood transfusion. And going by Aisha's attitudes toward drugs, she had never really completed a dose of any drug given for her treatment, because she found it difficult to swallow drugs. She always try to avoid taking

drugs. Only if it was possible for her not to get ill at all, it would have been so fair to her, because it would mean that she would never had to swallow drugs anymore.

Having convinced that there was need for the blood transfusion, Aisha's mother agreed to it, and the health workers wasted no effort in administering treatment.

Aisha was treated for malaria after which she took three pounds of blood. Fortunately for her, her brother was a match so she easily found a willing donor for the blood transfusion.

After the treatment Aisha was discharged. It is pertinent to remember that in the midst of all the health challenges and treatments, spanning from her journey to Kano for the wedding ceremony and treatment in the hospital, there was still the aspiration of studying Bio-Technology in the university. She had this admission to the university few months after she completed her Senior Secondary School Certificate Examination.

Aisha was expected to turn the house to another National Theatre as soon as she came back from admission in the hospital. The whole family expected that because of the excitement of her recent admission into the university which was obstructed by the excitements of the wedding ceremony she attended in Kano. Normally, Aisha would have continued with her jubilation of the university admission which meant a lot to her, but she didn't. what could be the reason? Is it that the admission no longer excites her? Everyone began to wonder. But it didn't take long for everyone in the house to discover that after the hospital experience, Aisha didn't get back to her usual ever bubbling self.

Aisha was becoming sluggish, and looking as though she was not the Aisha

that they used to know before her journey to Kano. She was becoming lazy gradually, as she found it difficult to deliver simple tasks successfully in the house.

Her mother didn't find this funny, and she believed that Aisha was changing and imbibing bad attitudes just because she felt she was no longer a teenager, and she was now on her way to becoming an undergraduate. This was the mother's assumptions because she could not relate Aisha's newly discovered attitudes to her recent health issues and experience at the hospital. This attitude was believed by her mother to be a pre-university attitude.

The mother being a typical African mother would sit Aisha down and gave loads of epistles of advice to her. She can't really be blamed. Who would have thought that this new Aisha had anything to do with a simple malaria treatment or the normal blood transfusion that can be conducted within hours? Could anyone ascribe this new lazy attitude to the new blood in her system? Would anyone be able to prove medically, scientifically or otherwise that she had contracted a new habit from the blood that was transfused into her body? So, no one can actually blame her mother for exercising the African Mother-hood traits in her.

The many epistles of advice given to Aisha by her mother would sometimes bore her and resulted to sudden and compulsory sleep. The mother would advise her on why as a young woman, she must be very smart and shun laziness. She would start brainstorming sessions of why as a young lady she must always be on her best behaviour. These and many advices became regular routine for Aisha.

What a poor Aisha. Enduring these loads of advices that were never closed to solving her attitudes switch was a serious

work. She didn't even know what was happening to her, but she knew something was wrong.

Sometimes, the mother would quarrel with her over her newly developed attitude of sluggishness, thinking she was becoming lazy as she was growing. Laziness is one character that her mother sworn never to let her develop. What an irony; because deep down something was actually wrong with Aisha that was way beyond character development.

Not quite long after Aisha was discharged from the hospital, she started having feverlike symptoms again. She was feeling weak, cold, and to add to that, she started having catarrh and all of these persist for more than a week. As they were trying to help her through these, her menstruation started. This compounded her health issues. She was totally down. If her menstruation had come gently, it would have been better, but it decided to be tough by coming along with a severe stomach pain. In her experience, Aisha felt like her internal organs were squeezed by something.

Aisha had never felt this bad before, as it appeared to be a battle of many grounds. Aisha's mother began to worry again. The major concern for her mother was that Aisha's menstrual period extended beyond the normal days. It did not stop when it should, and this added to Aisha's pain which got her mother worried.

There was need for another visit to the hospital, because it was obvious the current illness could no longer be managed at home.

Many will agree that the most informed decision to take when one is challenged with health issues is to visit the health facility for adequate care. This does not in any way negate the fact that the one God of the universe can miraculously heal his subjects from any form of illnesses. Afterall, He gave the people the

knowledge of science and health technology.

Arriving at the hospital, Aisha was examined and referred to a gynaecologist, who then instructed that some contraceptives should be administered to her in order to normalize her menstruation and cause some hormonal balance in her. Hmm, would one be wrong to say that science is miracle? How would a mere pill do that much?

Still in the hospital, Aisha's mother had an encounter with one of the typical Nigerian Nurse. The Nurse invited Aisha's mother to a corner and told her in a gossip manner that there is need to explore all options over Aisha's health issues. According to her, Aisha might have a boy who got her impregnated and aborted the pregnancy for her. The Nurse advised the mother to interview her properly to see if she would confess to such, so that they know the next step to take. Aisha's mother demoralised by this opinion of the Nurse about Aisha's situation to the point she almost shed tears. This was because she knew her daughter would never engage in such practice with another man, as she was thoroughly brought in a Godly way as a Muslim. So, she understood that she can't have any intimacy with a man except her husband. She saw the Nurse's suggestion as a wrong perception of her daughter.

Moreover, she strongly believes that Aisha was a virgin at the time and had never had any intimacy with any man. She felt bad about this whole thing because it was the health challenge that made her precious Aisha a subject of such ridicule. This opinion by the Nurse hurt Aisha's mother, but she absorbed the pain, thanked the Nurse for her suggestion and left.

Aside administering the contraceptives pill as instructed by the gynaecologist, some tests were conducted and it was discovered that Aisha's blood count was low again. This means that they had to perform another session of blood transfusion with Aisha. This news got her parents worried, in fact her mother didn't believe her hears, because it would mean another blood transfusion in the space of few weeks.

The first time the blood transfusion was performed on her, the Doctors said it was as a result of the malaria disease, the question now was, what could be the cause for the blood low count this time around.

One would definitely be worried at the suggestion of going through another procedure of blood transfusion within weeks after the first one.

Aisha's mother found it difficult to accept, so she told her daughter it doesn't make sense to have two different blood transfusion sessions within a space of one month. She suggested that they leave the hospital, and try another hospital the next day so as to have a second opinion. As they left the hospital, the fighting spirit in Aisha kicked in, and she told her mother, since they will be visiting a private hospital, they should just there straight, and there is no need to wait till the next day. The mother agreed and they turned around and went to another hospital.

On arrival at the hospital, they were asked to see a haematologist after series of examination. They eventually met a consultant haematologist in the hospital. The Doctor asked them some random questions which they quickly responded to. The doctor also proceeded by conducting some tests, and after that he told them to come the following day, so they can both look into the tests result and know the next line of action.

The following morning Aisha and her mother arrived at the hospital as early as possible, dressed as noble as possible with the hope of having a final solution to Aisha's prolonged illness. The hospital attendant led them to the Doctor who was also the same haematologist that attended to them the previous day. He looked at Aisha's mother in the eyes and asked her to invite her husband to the hospital immediately. This threw her aback, but she composed herself, and told the Doctor to tell her whatever the problem is, she insisted that she can withstand whatever the situation is. The Doctor insisted that she calls her husband, and when she realised the Doctor would not back down, she told him that her husband is currently in a training programme and he couldn't be reachable at that point in time. When the Doctor heard that, he looked at Aisha's mother again in the eyes and broke the news that sent the whole room into cold silence.

PONDER

1. Should parents learn not just the attitudes of their children, but the underlining factors producing those attitudes?
2. Can one be sensitive enough to properly understand the behavioural changes in others, and why they behave in certain ways?
3. Can science be attributed to divine intervention or miracle?
4. Can care for others help us understand what they are going through per time? [emotional intelligence]

CHAPTER TWO – THE GIRL

Aisha Abba Abdullahi, the 3AM Foundation warrior as she was often referred to was born on the 7th of August, 2001. She hailed from Mubi South Local Government Area of Adamawa State from the Northern Nigeria. Aisha was cheerful, loving, patient, and a strong warrior. Smiling face was her signature, and she showed everyone that had encountered with her that no matter what life throws at them, no matter how challenging life becomes, they must never give up.

Aisha in her days was inspired by the American wrestler named Roman Reigns. The wrestler was her motivation when she had to fight a deadly disease at some point in her life.

She showed everyone through her trying period that it is not how you fight to either win or lose a battle that matters, but how you lived throughout the battle period. She was a girl with coat of many colours. It can be said of her that she was no an ordinary person.

She handled challenges and uncomfortable situations as a child, teenager and youth amazed the elders around her. Elders are known in this part of the world as source of motivation the young ones, but in Aisha's case she was a source of motivation even to the elders that had encounters with her.

The testimony of many about her is that she could have been an angel sent to this world to live exemplary life, teaching young and old that life must be lived to the fullest with great joy without compromise, even in the face turbulent condition and chaos.

She radiated a great light that shone in the darkness of many. It is surprising that a girl of her age could make so much impact in a short while. No wonder her name will forever be remembered and remain relevant in the humanitarian world

for as long as her Foundation, the 3AM Foundation continues to be in existence. Aisha's positive attitude in the presence of a deadly storm was something that got the wise elders amazed. The day the news of the battle of the deadly storm that Aisha had to face head on was announced, everyone but Aisha was dumbfounded. It was as if a killer rock was just rolled towards their directions. But in all of this great silence, Aisha remained unburdened and she used her spirit positivity and optimism to brighten the atmosphere. She engaged even her mother such that the unforeseen deadly news that was broken didn't have a root to hold in the family.

While fighting for her life within the period of eight months, many shed tears that couldn't be measured, but Aisha the lead warrior only shed one tear. Just a drop of tear was her only emotional contribution to the situation. That was contributed on the war was declared in form of a breaking news by a haematologist at the hospital.

Aisha fought a ferocious battle with smiles, laughter, joy, cheerfulness and happiness. Who fights a ferocious battle with such ingredients if not Aisha Abba Abdullahi.

For her, this long eight months was an adventure. She took every event and every moment of the adventure, as they were unfolding one at a time, and as if they were nothing to worry about.

She lived every moment, living a trace behind for everyone to remind of her of. May be this is why a lot of positive people got drawn to her. Anywhere she turned to, she made quality and meaningful friends.

PONDER

1. What would you be remembered for?

2. What kind of people do you attract? (negative of positive)
3. How are you making impacts in your own little way?
4. How do you take on challenges, when they come your way?

CHAPTER THREE – THE MOTHER

I am Hajia Husseina Abdullahi, the mother of Aisha Abba Abdullahi.

On the 5th of March 2019, I was in the hospital with Aisha to see a haematologist whom we were referred to because of some illness that Aisha was experiencing. We had met him a day before, and he ran some tests on Aisha after which he asked us to come back to see him the following day, so that the result of the tests would have been out for him to know what was really wrong with her.

So, the following day being the 5th of March, we arrived at this office and as soon as he set his eyes on us, he asked me to put a call across to my husband to start coming. I was worried for a moment wondering he would want to see my husband before he could discuss the outcome of my daughter's tests result with me.

I summoned courage and requested that he speaks to me, as there won't be need for my husband to be physically present before he could discuss our daughter's health condition with me. The Doctor looked at me and paused for a moment. He later repeated the same statement, asking that I invite my husband to the hospital. When I realised that he won't talk to me until he sees my husband, I told him that my husband won't have the chance to come even if he wanted to come, because he was in a training programme as we speak, and I won't be able to reach him via a phone call.

As a matter of fact, I didn't see any reason for my husband to be brought into

this, because in my mind I was thinking that it was the malaria that was initially treated in the other hospital that escalated into the level probably because the treatment was not properly done, and I also assumed that the drugs given to her back there were not of good quality.

When I told him that my husband was at a training programme, he knew there was no way my husband would be able to make it down to the hospital at such short notice even if we could contact him on phone. It was then he looked at me in the eyes and said, 'your daughter has leukaemia.' And he explained further that, that was what they discovered from the tests carried out, and they would still have to conduct some confirmatory test such as bone marrow aspiration. But as far as they have seen, they are sure Aisha was suffering from leukaemia.

I was speechless and thoughtless at that point, because this was far beyond what I what I was expecting. I looked at Aisha, and she looked at me. I suddenly started thinking about what exactly is leukaemia. I was just trying to have a grasp of what leukaemia is.

The Doctor seeing how confused I was, cleared the air about what leukaemia is and said it's one of the types of blood cancer. I looked at my daughter again when he said that, wondering where that came from, and my daughter also focused her attention on me. We were both shocked and speechless. I remember seeing a tear rolled down her eyes. The Doctor in his wisdom gave us that moment to allow the information he just gave us sink.

While we were still in awe of the breaking news, he tried not to disturb by saying another one.

We had to walk out of his office without giving him any feedback. We went outside to call Aisha's father, because at that moment, I didn't really want to

believe anything, as I didn't know what to say or what to do. The only thought that narrowly found its way to my mind was the thought of calling Aisha's Father. At some point I told myself that the Doctor don't know what he was saying at all, and that maybe he got the wrong result. I remembered vividly that the only word that came out of my mouth while in the Doctor's office when he broke the news was maybe there was a mistake somewhere while they were trying to take the blood sample for the tests. I found it difficult to believe that a child that had always be strong and healthy right from her childhood suddenly developed an ailment as severe as cancer of the blood. As we sat at the hospital corridor waiting for Aisha's father, she turned to me and said "mummy, do you remember Roman Reigns, that American Wrestler?" and I said yes. In our house, they are a huge fan of wrestling, my kids watch it with their uncles. When she asked that question, I was thrown into another shocking moment, because I couldn't understand how Aisha could be thinking about a wrestler, she watches on TV at such a critical moment. re

So, when I said yes, she explained further to say Roman Reigns was away from wrestling for some months because of the same leukaemia, but he is back to the ring stronger than before, fighting again. Going by this, she doesn't think it's something really serious. I looked at her, and I wondered how she was able to be that positive. They just told us that she has cancer, and she called it something not really serious because a wrestler who used to have the same ailment is back to the ring fighting. As a matter of fact, aside that single tear that rolled down her cheek in the Doctor's office, she didn't exhibit form of sorrow again that day. She further said, Roman Reigns survived it, she will survive. She said the wrestler

didn't even look like someone who had been sick by the time he came back fighting.

At that point, I was beginning to look at her as someone I was meeting for the first time. I had known her to be a fearless and positive young girl, but never knew she look so much in control in a turbulent condition as difficult as this.

Given the fact that cancer was perceived as a death sentence especially in the part of the world, it baffled to me a young girl like her made it look like it's not a big thing.

As we were there processing the whole situation, her father came into the hospital and they both went back inside to see the Doctor. I couldn't go back with them, because I was still off balance.

We discussed further with the Doctor, and reach conclusion with him on the next line of action. They came out to meet me outside, and Aisha was smiling. She told me as soon as they came out that the Doctor said she needed blood transfusion immediately, and for that reason she needed to be admitted immediately for them to commence treatment.

I was looking at her and I was really confused, because she made the whole condition look like it was malaria that was diagnosed. I was really surprised about how she handled everything calmly and started jumping around everywhere in the office, and taking selfie at the same time. It was on that same day we were admitted to the hospital.

Aisha brought out her phone as soon as we were admitted and called her uncle to update him that she has been admitted in the hospital for medical care. She was very close to this particular uncle of hers, so she tells him everything happening with her. That's how much closed they were. After Aisha had given her uncle the full gist on how we were admitted, her

uncle asked why did they insist in the hospital that she had to be placed on admission. She jokingly told her uncle that she was feeling fine o, but the Doctor said she needed to shark blood o – ‘shark’ is a local slang for drink in Nigeria. That was her response to the question her uncle asked her. Aisha using words like ‘shark blood’ made the whole situation looked like a child’s play.

With her positive attitudes in the hospital, she was giving resounding hopes that I couldn’t even explained.

While on admission, blood samples were collected to run more tests, and in fact the Doctor on her case gave us some of the samples and insisted that we send them to another hospital to run test with them for second opinion. Aisha’ s dad had a friend who was a haematologist in University of Maiduguri Teaching Hospital. He was the one that the samples were sent to as advised by the Doctor. He carried out the test and call Aisha’s father back to confirm that it was true that Aisha had leukaemia. The truth remained that when those samples were sent to him in Maiduguri, I had wished that it didn’t come back positive for leukaemia. I wanted it to be that the hospital where we were that made some errors while running the tests. I wanted Aisha to free of leukaemia. It didn’t as imagine, Aisha really had leukaemia.

However, Aisha Dad’s friend in Maiduguri advised that we should see to it that treatment commences immediately.

Without wasting time, the treatment began, and the Doctor attending Aisha said she would need to go through chemotherapy procedure. They called induction. Aisha was taking the treatment positively, as she was taking pictures and sending them to her friends. Whatever food they served her in the hospital, she would snap and send to her friend, so that they can envy how much she was

enjoying herself at the hospital. To be candid, Aisha positive attitudes in the hospital made our stay in the hospital at the moment looked like an adventure.

Few days after hospital admission, chemotherapy procedure started. The Doctor was sincere and honest enough to tell us some of the common side effects of the chemo we should expect. He made it clear that there was possibility that Aisha would experience some severe side effects of the chemotherapy procedure.

As the chemo started, she didn’t experience any of the side effects that were described to us by the Doctor initially. In fact, she was in her normal happy self, few days into the chemotherapy procedure. But not long after that, the side effects kicked in and that changed the ball game.

Aisha who rarely get sad began to exhibit some mood switch that brought about some serious sad mood. She became withdrawn and extremely quiet. At a point she put away her phone that was once her best friend right there in the hospital. All my advice that she should keep her phone close, so that it would at least keep her busy, fell into deaf ears. She didn’t want to have anything to do with anyone, and any object. Quietness became her friend. She was constantly throwing up, as there was nothing that stayed in her mouth or stomach. Sometimes she would have leg pains, to the extent that she won’t be able to walk, and at times she felt so weak that lifting her hands because some sort of hard labour.

Her mood completely changed. At some point she also felt pains all over her body, and it was really tough on her because in the middle of all of this, she was also receiving blood transfusion. Can it be worse than this was her case at the time. Getting blood for Aisha wasn’t difficult at all, because she had many people willing

to donate for her. There were friends, and family members ready to be screened in order to donate for Aisha, and this really help a lot. Though at some point we ran out of donor because not all willing donors were match, and even those that were a match could only donate the next three months after their first donation, So, when we realized that donor was going to become a problem, we depended on the hospital blood bank for the transfusion. This helped a lot because Aisha was consistently receiving the blood transfusion throughout the period of chemotherapy procedures.

As the chemo side effects persist, Aisha's joyous self was disappearing. As soon as we discovered this, I and her father had a discussion, and we decided to surprise her with something we felt she couldn't resist, something she had been desiring for a long time. Aisha had always wanted her father to buy an iphone 8 phone for her. She had an iphone, but it was an old version, so she wanted something recent and her choice was iphone 8 then. In order to bring her back to her cheerful and happy self, her father purchased the phone and presented it to her at the hospital. To our surprise, Aisha didn't even touch the phone for days, let alone using it. It was then we realised that the chemo had really took a negative turn on her.

It is pertinent to know that the chemotherapy procedures administered to her killed every cell in her body. The chemo was targeted at the affected cells in the body, but it usually brings down every other cell in the body, as a result of this, we were made to know that Aisha's immune system was down, and she had to be placed on isolation. This was to ensure that she did not have contact with anyone with infection which would definitely affect her because her defence walls were down. Because of this, no one

was allowed to come into her room for visitation, not even if her father. I that was even allowed to see her would always be on my nose mask, with a lot of hand sanitizing, and sometimes I had to use disposable gloves.

Fortunately for us, the Doctor that attended to Aisha was very, friendly and accommodating. He always made himself available whenever Aisha called on him, and they would talk and gist for as long as possible, as due to their level of closeness, he became Aisha's confidant. Aisha trusted and liked him so much. He made himself available as Aisha's gist partner. This I must say helped her during her stay in the hospital. Meanwhile, for a month Aisha was in the hospital going through this series of test and treatments.

As soon as the chemo sessions were completed, Aisha was placed on observation, and tests were being carried out on daily basis to ascertain her level of stability. In fact, tests became a daily routine for Aisha. They would come, take her blood sample for test. Without mincing words, Aisha went through a lot during this period. Her hands turned to purple in the process as a result of needle insertion to either take blood sample, giver her injection or for blood transfusion for chemotherapy procedures. She also lost weight and looked lighter to the extent that it became difficult to recognize her.

While in the hospital one day, I decided to help her loose her hair and replate it to make look decent. Her father was around with us that day and he agreed to it. As I tried to loosen the first line of the hair, I was surprised and saddened with what I saw. I saw with my eyes, Aisha's hair fallen off. This was something we never thought about throughout the period she was being prepared for the procedure. I couldn't continue loosening the hair,

because I wouldn't want her to see that. Her father saw it too, but kept quiet just as I did. Aisha who was lying on the bed at that moment didn't see a thing, so we left it at that. I just told her that he should let us fix the hair another time, so that she could rest well and I wouldn't want to disturb her that day in the name of plating a new hairstyle. This particular condition caught me unawares, I never prepared for it, because no one told us this was going to happen, but I had to comport myself so that Aisha won't notice anything. Because if she noticed it, she would break down completely. How do I explain to a young girl like her that her hair was fallen off just for a mere touch. Unfortunately, some part of the hair had already fallen off when I touched it. So, I knew it's a matter of time, Aisha would see it. Just as I had thought, she went into the bathroom that day to ease herself and on getting to the bathroom, she looked into the mirror and saw the part of her hair that fell off. She quickly reconciled it to the reason I left the hair earlier on the bed, when I wanted to loosen it. She came out of the bathroom looking very sad. It did not go down with her at all. She was just screaming "mummy my hair is falling off." It was a very sad moment for her. That made her feel depressed. I knew that was going to happen whenever she discovered it, and that was why I tried to prevent her from seeing the fallen hair.

At a point, she started exhibiting fear, I remember she told me that she was having negative thoughts, doubting if she would survive it. On those occasions of her doubts, I usually tell her to keep having faith, and never entertained any thought of negativity in her mind and I believe that she would be completely restored. Her present unpleasant health condition was becoming too overwhelming for her.

Having gone through all the procedures, they placed her on medications to stabilize her. This also was another big challenge for her, because she's someone who doesn't like swallowing drugs. They were too many medications that even got me irritated but there was nothing we could do about it. It was part of the procedure for the cancer treatment, to ensure that she's back on her feet and that was the primary objective.

Gradually, Aisha started picking up. The first day she opened her mouth to request for food for the first time in a long time was a miracle for us all, it gladdens our heart. She started eating gradually, though she still throws up, but it has really reduced. We saw her getting back on her feet poco a poco.

Aisha started doing the things she used to do when she was healthy. As a matter of fact, she rose up from on a certain morning, picked up her new phone and smile at it. I was really happy about this development, as it showed us that she was improving and gradually returning to the Aisha we know. Truth be told, Aisha was the type that creates joyful atmosphere, so seeing sad for many days was not pleasing to us.

The Doctors came and started giving us assurances. They told she has started recovering, but they also advised that we fly her abroad for bone marrow transplant as soon as we have the means to do so. Unfortunately, we were told there was no hospital in Nigerian that render such service, so we had to depend on flying her abroad for the the transplant.

As the day passed by, she became better and her blood count was stabled, she started eating well, everything began to look normal again, in fact it looked like the light has shone at the end of the tunnel. In no time she was discharged. Every member of the family was very happy to have Aisha back.

At home, people came trouping in to visit Aisha. It was mixed-feelings for a lot of them that came. They didn't know if they should celebrate or cry. Sometimes they cry, sometimes they laugh, and sometimes they neither laugh nor sob. It was a lot of emotional attachment for them.

While in the house, some of her friends would come and sometimes cried, because of how Aisha's look, which was pleasant to the eyes. She lost weight and had become indecently dark and sickly. They were not happy with the version of Aisha they saw. Some of them would come and make jokes with her scanty hair that had almost completely fell off, and they shall all laugh and Aisha would also laugh with them. They did that to make her laugh and happy. Visitors never stopped, because Aisha was the type that easily attracts people. When she was in the hospital, her friend missed her a lot. So, I wasn't bothered about the crowd that gathered in the house on a daily basis.

Back in the house, Aisha began to recover speedily, and her body was coming back. She started gaining back her appetite, and began to eat well. She was also taking her medications regularly, and as prescribed by the Doctors. In all of this, Aisha was positive. She took everything in good faith.

It is pertinent to remember that the Doctors had previously advised that we take him abroad for bone marrow transplant. That option was still there while we were allowing Aisha to enjoy her moment at home.

Having gone through the chemotherapy procedures here in Nigeria, Aisha was afraid of what she may have to go through during the process of the transplant, so I encouraged her that she should not bother about the transplant, because medical treatment about is

always top notch. I said that to calm her nerves, I didn't really know what medical abroad looked like.

After a while, we got referred to an hospital abroad for the bone marrow transplant, Egypt to be précised. The thought of flying got her excited, and she was very happy about. I could recall how she would come to meet me to say, she would be traveling abroad for her health care, and how she felt about it. The only in her mouth then was that she would be traveling outside Nigeria for the first time. To her it was an opportunity for another adventure. The first adventure was when she was at the hospital in Nigeria for one month, now she would be going for the second adventure in Egypt. God knows for how long we would be away from Nigeria. So, we started making preparations for the journey and Aisha was very happy about it.

Having made all preparations about the journey for the medical tour, Aisha needed to be fully back on her feet. We couldn't allow anything to cause any form of delay in rescuing our girl completely. We set a date for the journey hence the journey to rescue Aisha began.

PONDER

1. What defines you as a person?
2. What is the quality of thought, what thoughts fill your mind? (negative or positive)
3. What kind of people do you have around you?